



A STRIKE in Iraq, above, targeted Iran-backed militants after attacks on U.S. forces and Saudi oil facilities. YOUNIS AL-BAYATI AFP/Getty Images

ATTACKS BY IRAN, U.S. DIM PEACE HOPES

Strikes spread to Iraq, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia and threaten to engulf even more countries.

By SAMY MAGDY AND ELENA BECATOROS

CAIRO — The United States and Iran each fired barrages of missiles Thursday, as the pattern of back-and-forth strikes took hold again and hope for an end to the five-month-long war faded.

Following a few days of respite, fears of a wider war have grown, with renewed fighting threatening to engulf even more countries: Jordan said Thursday it intercepted Iranian missiles for the second consecutive day, and Kuwait said a strike in the northern part of the country killed one person. Also this week, drones caused fires on ships at an Egyptian port, and Saudi Arabia said it came under fire from Iran-backed militias in Iraq.

The war — which was supposed to last four to five weeks, President Trump said in its early days, although he warned it could take longer — has caused the price of fuel to spike and roiled the global economy. As months have passed, concerns have deepened about using up the stockpile of weapons the U.S. needs to defend its bases and allies.

Meanwhile, the war is unpopular among Americans, and a new AP-NORC poll says Trump's approval rating on Iran has dipped slightly since last month.

The recent pause in fighting, which began over the weekend and spurred hopes among mediators of diplomacy

[See Iran war, A4]

As housing pressures mount, rental scams rise

Police are seeing more phony online listings

By Grace Toohey

Pam Yeager thought she had found her perfect next rental in a cute bungalow near downtown Fullerton.

It seemed like a no-brainer: It was priced slightly below the region's average for a two-bedroom home, would allow her to live closer to her son and was available right as her lease was expiring.

But it turned out to be one big scam, costing her thousands of dollars to online fraudsters.

"It's ridiculous," Yeager, 53, said. "There has to be some sort of accountability."

But experts say it's a scenario that is becoming more common and difficult to police.

In California, an incredibly tight housing market and high rents are fueling a new generation of real estate scams that take advantage of people desperate to find an affordable place to live.

Officials say the scammers place fake listings on social media and other online marketplaces, sometimes using artificial intelligence to make the content appear legitimate. Often, they simply take existing listings and repost them, collecting as

much money as they can before victims learn they were never in touch with a legitimate landlord.

And as more people are turning to social media to find rentals and homes for sale, police say it's created a ripe environment for scammers, given many platforms' limited regulation and oversight.

The fake ads often offer what appear to be unbeatable deals — capitalizing on people's desperation.

"Especially in this housing market, it gets competitive and people feel pressure to act quickly," said Orange County Sheriff's Department spokesperson Sgt. Elizabeth Gwisdalla, who said the department regularly investigates these types of online rental scams. "If it sounds too good to be true, it probably is too good to be true."

Real estate professionals across the state have seen cybercrimes like these increasing, said Chris Duff, president of Greater Los Angeles Realtors Assn. and co-owner of Beach Real Estate Group.

"This is not something new, it's just rising," Duff said. "It's getting worse every year."

Just last

[See Scams, A8]

ABC strikes back at the FCC

Threat to station licenses is political payback on behalf of Trump, Disney says.

By MEG JAMES

The Federal Communications Commission has demanded for months that ABC prove its stations deserve to stay on the air — a proceeding with no precedent in the last half-century. This week, the network delivered a sharp retort, accusing the agency of waging a campaign of political retribution.

"The retaliation against ABC is a signal to every media company in the country: accommodate the Administration's view of what news

coverage should look like or pay the price," Walt Disney Co.'s attorneys wrote in the 109-page filing late Wednesday.

ABC has enlisted prominent elected officials, community organizations and seasoned litigators for the 1st Amendment showdown that could ultimately reach the U.S. Supreme Court.

The Burbank entertainment giant's combative stance comes after the FCC, led by Chairman Brendan Carr, took the rare step this spring of demanding that Disney defend the broadcast licenses of its eight ABC stations — including KABC-TV Channel 7 in Los Angeles — years before the permits were set to expire.

The government's move represents a significant threat to Disney because the

loss of licenses would hobble the ABC network by forcing its largest stations off the air. Other ABC stations at risk include those in San Francisco, Fresno, Philadelphia and New York.

The FCC is expected to make a determination next month. It could require ABC to defend the stations in a hearing or before the commission.

The FCC, in a statement, defended its inquiry and hinted that it may go further. "For decades, Americans of all stripes have been subsidizing broadcast media to the tune of many billions of dollars by giving TV stations free use of a valuable, public resource — the airwaves," an FCC spokesperson said in a statement.

"Broadcasters are re-

[See ABC, A12]

Harrowing rescue yields a teenage hero

By Grace Toohey

The dramatic footage of a teenage lifeguard saving a child from punishing waves along the California coast has captured the attention of the nation, drawing praise from the shores of Santa Cruz all the way to the White House.

Video of the rescue at Seabright State Beach on July 25, captured and shared by local photographer Scott Vander Dussen, has gone viral on virtually every social media platform. The footage shows the rookie lifeguard, just 16 years old, holding on to a limp child as massive swells repeatedly pound the



SCOTT VANDER DUSSEN @santacruznow

RYDER WILLIAMS, 16, saves a young boy in Santa Cruz on July 25. The footage has gone viral nationally.

duo.

They eventually make it to shore with the help of a second lifeguard. No one suffered any serious injuries, officials said.

President Trump reshared the video in a post on X, calling the teen a "heroic young man" who he hopes will come to the White House to be properly honored for his valor.

"Very brave, he deserves it!" the president said.

But in a statement, lifeguard Ryder Williams said he was simply doing the job he loves. This summer is his first as a California State Parks lifeguard.

"I'm grateful to have had

[See Lifeguard, A8]

Few ways, and little time, left to win over voters

Any moves by Trump are unlikely to bring economic relief before midterms, experts say.

By KEVIN RECTOR, JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — With three months remaining until election day, there is now little the Trump administration can do to bring relief to Americans battered by years of stagnant wages and steep inflation before they hit the polls, experts say — complicating midterm campaigning for Republicans and sharpening the opportunity for Democrats to win back some control in Washington.

That's in part because the Trump administration has very few levers to turn the tide in such a short period, and has shown little interest in using those it does have, experts said. Rather, President Trump has persisted in waging war in Iran and pushed forward with new tariffs on trade partners despite both contributing to soaring costs for food, gas

and other basic necessities.

Other options, such as issuing rebate checks for consumers or releasing strategic oil reserves, would be costly in the long run, experts said.

"There isn't much available on a 14-week clock that doesn't cost more later than it delivers now," said Patrick Harker, a professor at the University of Pennsylvania Wharton School and former president of the Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia.

The Federal Reserve on Wednesday also declined to use its primary tool for reducing inflation — increasing interest rates — by instead holding rates steady. Trump had not supported a rate increase, instead pressuring the central bank to lower rates, which can lower borrowing costs but increase inflation.

Some factors driving up costs are virtually impossible to resolve in the near term, such as damage to oil refining capabilities in the Middle East as a result of the war in Iran. Others are already baked into pricing to come as a result of tariffs and fuel costs, including for groceries, experts said.

[See Economy, A6]



MARK SCHIEFFELBEIN Associated Press

ACTING ATTY. GEN. Todd Blanche is sworn in before the Senate Judiciary Committee on July 15.

Trump's IRS deal hurdle for Blanche

GOP senators make demands to move attorney general nomination forward.

By BEN WIEDER

WASHINGTON — The high-stakes nomination of Todd Blanche to be attorney general has turned into a clash of wills between President Trump and two Senate Republicans whose political careers he claims credit for ending.

After a vote on Blanche's nomination was delayed over concerns raised by two lame-duck Republican senators, the president said Thursday he might put Blanche's nomination on hold rather than meet their demands.

Sens. John Cornyn (R-Texas) and Thom Tillis (R-N.C.) have indicated that they will vote to support advancing Blanche's nomination only if the Justice Department provides written assurance that it has completely abandoned a controversial \$1.8-billion "anti-weaponization" fund cre-

ated as part of a settlement between Trump and the Internal Revenue Service and will limit the scope of tax audit immunity granted to Trump, his sons and a business.

Those provisions were part of a proposed settlement of a \$10-billion lawsuit Trump filed against the IRS, which is part of his administration.

"The opposition to such a high-ranking executive branch nomination from within Republican ranks is quite unprecedented," said Phil Brest, who was a top Democratic staffer for the Senate Judiciary Committee during the nominations of attorneys general Jeff Sessions, William Barr and Merrick Garland.

The Senate careers of both Cornyn and Tillis are coming to an end this year after Trump declined to endorse them.

"John Cornyn, of Texas, and Thom Tillis, of North Carolina, both of whom I refused to endorse, and whose political careers have been ended by my action, are refusing to vote for this Great Nominee," Trump wrote on

[See Blanche, A6]

Migrant kids may lose representation

Federal contract that funds nonprofits' legal services is ending; advocates are alarmed. **NATION, A5**

SoCal braces for unrelenting heat

Forecasters warn of hazardous conditions through the weekend. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 92/69. **B6**

Markets **A12**
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Sony to expand 'Jeopardy!' brand

Game show franchise seeks younger audiences with sports and other spinoffs. **BUSINESS, A10**

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